

Cloud Kitchen Launch Plan

Biryani-Focused • Metro City • Lean Budget (Under ₹5 Lakh)

This plan covers legal setup, location, equipment, staffing, platform strategy, a full budget breakdown, menu & per-plate costing, and a 30-day launch checklist — scoped for a small team starting lean in a metro city.

Category	Detail
Cuisine focus	Biryani / rice-based, 4-6 item menu
City tier	Metro (e.g. Bangalore / Mumbai / Delhi)
Total budget	Under ₹5,00,000 (setup + 1st month)
Core team	1 Head Cook + 1 Helper (+ founder handling ops)
Sales channel	Swiggy / Zomato (primary) + WhatsApp direct (repeat orders)

Note: This is a planning guide with typical metro-city cost ranges as of 2026. Actual costs vary by city, locality and vendor — always get 2-3 local quotes before committing.

1. Legal & Registration

Start this in Week 1 — it has the longest lead time (2-4 weeks) and blocks your launch.

Requirement	Approx Cost	Notes
FSSAI State License	■2,000 – 7,500 / yr	Mandatory for food business; varies by state & turnover slab
GST Registration	Free	Required to list on Swiggy / Zomato
Shop & Establishment License	■1,000 – 5,000	City/state dependent
Trade name + basic logo	■2,000 – 5,000	Can DIY to save cost initially

Total: ■15,000 – 20,000 | Timeline: ~1 month (start immediately)

2. Location

- **Preferred route:** Shared/cloud kitchen space (e.g. Rebel Foods, Kitchen Centre or local shared-kitchen operators) — rent a slot/hours, shared exhaust & gas infra already in place. Lowest upfront cost.
- **Alternative:** Small standalone unit (100–150 sq ft) in a residential/light-commercial area — no footfall needed, only delivery access.
- Avoid high-street/commercial-premium locations — you don't need walk-in customers.

Budget: ■15,000–30,000/month rent + ■30,000–60,000 deposit (2 months)

This is typically your largest fixed recurring cost — negotiate hard, or use the shared-kitchen route to avoid the deposit entirely.

3. Kitchen Equipment (Biryani-Focused)

Item	Approx Cost
Commercial gas stove/burner (2-3 burner)	■8,000 – 15,000
Biryani handis / degs (2-3 sizes)	■8,000 – 12,000
Commercial rice cooker / steamer (large)	■10,000 – 15,000
Refrigerator / deep freezer (used is fine)	■15,000 – 25,000
Prep tables & storage racks	■10,000 – 15,000
Exhaust / chimney (skip if shared kitchen)	■15,000 – 25,000
Utensils, ladles, cutting tools	■8,000 – 10,000
Packaging (biryani-safe boxes, sealing)	■10,000 (recurring)
Weighing scale + gas cylinder connection	■5,000 – 8,000
TOTAL	■90,000 – 1,35,000

Tip: Buy used/refurbished commercial equipment from second-hand commercial kitchen dealers — saves 30–40% and is common practice for new cloud kitchens.

4. Staffing (Cook & Helpers)

A focused biryani menu doesn't need a full kitchen brigade. Start lean:

Role	Count	Monthly Salary (Metro)	Notes
Head Cook (Biryani specialist)	1	■18,000 – 30,000	Your make-or-break hire. Prefer someone from a biryani-specific background.
Helper / Prep hand	1	■10,000 – 15,000	Chopping, marination prep, cleaning, packing
Delivery	0	—	Use Swiggy/Zomato riders initially. Don't hire your own fleet until volume justifies it.
Founder / You	—	—	Orders, platform management, quality control, procurement

Total staffing: ■28,000 – 45,000/month — your biggest recurring cost. Start with just 2 people and add headcount only once order volume justifies it.

5. Platform & Marketing

- List on **Swiggy & Zomato** — free to list, but expect 18–28% commission per order. Budget for this margin hit from day one.
- Set up a free **Google Business Profile** for local search visibility.
- Set up **WhatsApp Business** ordering for repeat customers — near-zero cost and keeps some orders commission-free over time.
- Professional food photography: ■3,000 – 5,000 (biryani sells heavily on visuals — don't skip this).
- Launch offers/discounts buffer: ■5,000 – 10,000.

6. Total Budget Breakdown (Month 1)

Category	Cost Range
Licensing & registration	■15,000 – 20,000
Rent + deposit (2 months)	■45,000 – 90,000
Equipment	■90,000 – 1,35,000
Staff (1st month salary)	■28,000 – 45,000
Raw material (1st month stock)	■30,000 – 50,000
Packaging	■10,000
Marketing / photography	■8,000 – 15,000
Buffer / contingency	■20,000 – 30,000
TOTAL	■2,46,000 – 3,95,000

This fits comfortably under ■5 lakh with contingency room — but the shared-kitchen route (avoiding separate rent/exhaust/deposit) is what makes this genuinely comfortable rather than tight.

7. Menu & Per-Plate Costing (Illustrative)

Indicative costing for a focused biryani menu. Treat food-cost % as the key health metric: aim to keep raw material cost at 30–35% of selling price to leave room for packaging, commission and margin.

Item	Est. Raw Cost/Plate	Suggested Price	Food Cost %
Veg Biryani	■45 – 55	■150 – 180	~30%
Chicken Biryani	■70 – 90	■220 – 260	~33%
Mutton Biryani	■130 – 160	■380 – 440	~35%
Egg Biryani	■50 – 60	■160 – 190	~32%
Specialty (house special)	■90 – 120	■280 – 320	~34%
Raita / Side (add-on)	■8 – 12	■30 – 40	~28%

Remember: The selling price above is your menu price on Swiggy/Zomato before commission. After an 18–28% platform commission, your effective margin on a ■220 chicken biryani (cost ■80) can shrink from ~64% gross margin to roughly 40–45% net — factor this into pricing rather than pricing only against raw food cost.

8. 30-Day Launch Checklist

Week 1-2: Foundations

- Apply for FSSAI license and GST registration
- Finalize biryani style and lock a 4-6 item menu (e.g. Chicken, Mutton, Veg Biryani + 1 specialty)
- Start hunting for shared kitchen space or a small standalone unit
- Get 2-3 quotes each for equipment (new vs. used) and rent options

Week 2-3: Setup

- Hire the Head Cook first — run a paid trial batch and taste-test before committing
- Finalize kitchen space and complete equipment purchase/installation
- Set up packaging supplier (biryani-safe boxes, bulk order for cost savings)
- Hire helper/prep hand

Week 3-4: Go-Live Prep

- Register and list on Swiggy and Zomato with professional food photography
- Set up Google Business Profile and WhatsApp Business ordering
- Do a soft launch with a tight delivery radius (2-3 km) to control quality and delivery time
- Run a launch discount/offer to generate first reviews and ratings

Week 4+: Track & Iterate

- Track cost-per-order vs. platform commission weekly
- Monitor food cost % against the 30-35% target per item
- Decide on expanding delivery radius or menu based on actual order volume and repeat-order rate
- Push repeat customers toward WhatsApp direct ordering to reduce commission dependency over time

Prepared as a planning reference. Costs are indicative metro-city ranges (2026) and will vary by exact city, locality, and vendor negotiations — validate key numbers locally before committing capital.